

Stone Age painting

The first painters made images on rocks and cave walls using natural pigments, mixed with saliva or animal fat, and applied with fingers, sticks, moss or bones. The most famous are lifelike paintings of animals, including bison, horses and cattle. Sometimes natural variations on the walls were used to create three-dimensional effects. The inaccessibility of most of these caves suggest that they were not dwellings, but that the paintings were probably part of religious rituals, perhaps intended to evoke hunting success.

Despite the crude materials and the conditions in which they worked, many Palaeolithic artists demonstrate accomplished skills in rendering tone, movement and foreshortening. This is apparent at Lascaux in southwest France, where about 300 paintings and 1,500 engravings decorate two large caves c.17,300 years old. Similar images have been found in other caves across the world. Few realistic humans are depicted – instead, human presence often appears as hand prints.



Lascaux cave painting, c.17,300 BCE